

General Lit.





About the Course

Read living books full of memorable characters, surprising plot twists, and heartwarming endings. Due to the rise of Children's Literature in the 19th century, students read period literature rather than historical fiction this year and will spend about a term and a half each with Little Women and Hans Brinker.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Literature: Grades 5-6

About Literature: Grades 5-6

Overview note: Literature selections are chosen to encourage students to engage with rich ideas in literature and history and also to help them to gain independence in their reading and lessons.



Placement & Combining Tips

About Literature: Grades 5-6

Overview note: Literature selections are chosen to encourage students to engage with rich ideas in literature and history and also to help them to gain independence in their reading and lessons.

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

Easily combined with Grade 4.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
5-6	General Lit.: Grades 5-6 1 time/week 20 min	Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates Little Women

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Literature: Grades 5-6				
Lit./Mythology: Grade 5-6		General Lit.: Grades 5-6		



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Term Prep & Teacher Tips

Literature: Grades 5-6

The Extra Helping writing prompts in the lessons are used as composition prompts in grades 7-8, and they are only for students who want to dive deeper or experiment with writing at this level.

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

□ For the Silver Skates, we have provided two different pacing options for the book depending on your student(s) and context. The first pacing option is slower and better suited for less confident readers reading independently OR those reading the book aloud with their student(s). Note that students will want to finish this book on their own time after the end of the year.

The second pacing option moves more quickly and allows students to finish the book. This is best suited to quick readers or those who want to assign any reading not finished in a lesson for students to complete as homework on their own time during the term.

Regardless of which pacing option you choose, be sure to leave time for students to narrate at the end of the lesson. Note that recap and discussion questions are based on the slower pacing, so feel free to skip ahead and use a discussion question from a different lesson if you're following the faster option.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

General Lit.: Grades 5-6



Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates



Little Women



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Related Course Quick Links

∞ [Foundations \(See Section 9: Literature\)](#)

Click [THIS text](#)
or scan the QR
[code for links.](#)



General Lit.: Grades 5-6

How To Teach



Prepare

- Read through the lesson and gather any materials or find any necessary links.
- If you have not already read the book, you may want to read the selected pages in advance, especially for Shakespeare lessons. It is helpful to read the play or a preview of it beforehand.
- Choose which books to have students read independently. See Planning and Prep notes for recommendations.



Recap

- Connect back to the previous lesson. Ask students to give a summary of what they remember and/or predict what might come next. (Full narration is not necessary.)
- If students have difficulty recalling, try showing an illustration, sharing something that you remember, or prompting them with the first sentence of the last reading. This will often refresh their memory enough to allow them to recall.
- If students still cannot recall anything from the last reading, then consider continuing anyway (with a shorter reading and/or using a combination of visual and audio support this time) or repeating the last lesson, depending on the reading and the nature of the book.



Introduce

- Use a picture, map, or engaging question to pique the student's interest in the day's lesson.
- If necessary, you may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding.



Read

- Read the day's passage aloud or have students read independently. For Shakespeare, it is highly recommended that each student have their own copy of the play and that you read it aloud together or read along and underline/make notes while listening to the audio recording.
- Use supportive strategies and educational tools to reduce frustration and better engage the mind, as appropriate. These could include, but are not limited to, the use of eBooks, pictures, audio, read-aloud, buddy reading, colored reading strips, etc.
- Some students may benefit from having a notebook or piece of scrap paper available to externalize ideas by drawing, recording names, or making symbolic 'squiggle' notes.
- Students who have a difficult time sitting still or listening may benefit from: a fidget of their choice, such as a piece of putty or clay or an afghan; flexible positioning, such as a wobble seat or inverted sitting; or sensory modulation, such as a weighted vest or blanket or adjustment of light, temperature, or sound.
- Keep an eye out for things to add to your Book of Centuries, Citizenship Notebook, and Copywork book.



Narrate

- Have students retell the passage orally or in writing. If writing, encourage students to use the full remaining lesson time and include as much detail as they can remember. For Shakespeare or

challenging books, it may be helpful to narrate more frequently and/or use props.

- Alternatively, learners may use words, pictures, legos, dolls, etc. to process and convey ideas in the manner most natural to them.
- Students who used paper or a notebook to externalize may refer to these for support. Other students who need external support may benefit from looking at a map or picture from the book while narrating.
- Students who tend to use the same type of narration all the time, can be encouraged to try another form of narration by first doing it together through play or discussion.
- Teachers may take turns to model.
- Narration is a complex skill that requires the coordination of several parts of the brain. If a student struggles to narrate in general, with a specific subject or book, or on one day but not others, then this is an opportunity to learn. Observe when they struggle with this or any other activity today; notice facial expressions and body language; listen to what they tell about why it is hard or how they feel about it. Take note of these observations for later, tell them that you see how hard they are working, and then offer whatever support they need to end on a positive note or take a break for the day, if necessary.



Discuss

- Give the student an opportunity to share thoughts on the lesson and any connections made.
- To stimulate discussion, you can ask an open-ended question or use an included discussion question.

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 1

Materials: Little Women

PREP: Read the bio and share parts with your students in the lesson.
∞ Article Link: Louisa May Alcott Bio

→ INTRO

Little Women was published in 2 volumes. We will read Volume 1, published originally in 1868. Little Women was the first American novel written for girls, though it had wide appeal upon publication, with boys, adult women, and men as well. It was a move away from overly preachy children's literature and was an immediate success, changing how novels for young people were written.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.1 "Playing Pilgrims"

- If you read Pilgrim's Progress in younger grades, keep an eye out for many different references or allusions to the book as you read Little Women. Did you notice any in this chapter? [Hint: the name of the chapter is one reference!]

★ TEACHER NOTE

See Extra Helpings for suggested audio versions, as this can be a fun book to listen to in the afternoons or at other times to create flexibility in your schedule.

• IMPORTANT DATES

Little Women published (1868 AD)

WEEK 2 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 2

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

Who are the "Little Women" and what is the setting for the book?

→ INTRO

Name as many things as you can that are happening in the world during the late 1800s when Little Women was written and published.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.2 "A Merry Christmas"

- How do the March sisters show joy despite their circumstances?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Christmas During the Civil War

WEEK 3 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 3

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What was Christmas like in the March home?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.3 "The Laurence Boy"

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Civil War Dresses

WEEK 4 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 4

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

Who did the March sisters meet in the last chapter? What is he like?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.4 "Burdens"

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Link: The Alcotts' Home, which was the inspiration for the Marchs' home.

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

- Describe some of the burdens the sisters feel they carry. Which seems hardest to you?

WEEK 5 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 5

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What are some of the chores or work the sisters are responsible for?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.5 "Being Neighborly"

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Transcendentalism and the Alcotts

• EXTRA HELPINGS

Read this memorial poem about Thoreau by Alcott.

∞ Link: Thoreau's Flute

Read about the link between Alcott and Ralph Waldo Emerson in the article linked below.

∞ Article Link: Alcott and Emerson

WEEK 6 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 6

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

How did Jo show kindness to a neighbor?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.6-7 "Beth Finds the Palace Beautiful" and "Amy's Valley of Humiliation"

- Optional: Have you been noticing the allusions to Pilgrim's Progress? What kind of journey are each of the sisters on, and how is that similar (or dissimilar) to the Pilgrim's journey?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Pickled Limes

WEEK 7 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 7

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What lesson did Amy learn in the last chapter?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.8 "Jo Meets Apollyon"

- What are some of the lessons about anger and temper in this chapter? Do you agree?

• EXTRA HELPING

Pick a scene from the story thus far to turn into a short play.

WEEK 8 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 8

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What lesson did Jo learn in the last chapter?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.9 "Meg Goes to Vanity Fair"

- What temptations does Meg face, and how does she recover?

WEEK 9 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 9

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What lesson did Meg learn in the last chapter?

• EXTRA HELPING

Write up your idea that you discussed in the lesson! Compose an advertisement, article, or poem for the Pickwick Portfolio. You can retell a scene from Little Women or choose something from

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 1

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
Ch.10 "The P.C. and P.O."

- If you wrote something for the Pickwick Portfolio, what would you write?

another book or even your personal experience to write about. One idea: write a newspaper entry about the admission of "Sam Weller" into the club.

WEEK 10 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 10

Materials: Little Women

→ **RECAP**

Describe the Pickwick Club. Would you want to join?

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
Ch.11 "Experiments"

- Why do the experiments fail, and what lessons do the girls learn?

WEEK 11 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 11

Materials: Little Women

→ **RECAP**

What was the "experiment" in the last chapter?

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
Ch.12 "Camp Laurence"

★ TEACHER NOTE

This is a longer chapter and can be finished in the afternoon or next week during exam week.

WEEK 12 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 12

Exam Week

→ **EXAMS**

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:
Little Women

★ TEACHER NOTE

Finish chapter from last week as needed.

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Term 2

WEEK 1 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 13

Materials: Little Women

→ INTRO

What does your "dream future" look like 5 or 10 years from now?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.13 "Castles in the Air"

• EXTRA HELPING

Write a profile or character sketch of one of the sisters. What are they like? Write as if you were telling a friend about them.

WEEK 2 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 14

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What were some of the sisters' dreams in the previous chapter?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Beginning of Ch.14 "Secrets" - "saying she would call her mother" p.253 (middle of Ch.15)

- How does Alcott use the contrasting personalities of the sisters as foils? A foil is when an author contrasts two characters to emphasize some of their qualities. The word foil refers to backing gems with foil to make them shine brighter.

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

With the remaining time or in the afternoon, learn more about the telegraph.

∞ Video Link: The Telegraph: The Civil War Text Machine

• IMPORTANT DATES

Telegraph invented (1830s)

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: LMA, Civil War Nurse

WEEK 3 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 15

Materials: Little Women

→ INTRO

What does good comfort look and feel like? What are ways you've been comforted when sad or ways that people have tried to comfort you unhelpfully?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.15 p.253 "Everything was arranged" - end of Ch.16 "Letters"

• EXTRA HELPING

Write a letter to Jo comforting her during Beth's illness.

★ TEACHER NOTE

Beth likely had Scarlet Fever. Share from or view this short video as desired.

∞ Video Link: Scarlet Fever

WEEK 4 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 16

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

What do you think will happen next?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.17-18 "Little Faithful" & "Dark Days"

- Make a character chart of Amy's virtues versus her vanities.

WEEK 5 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 17

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

How did the sisters show care for others in the previous chapters?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

• EXTRA HELPING

Tell about Amy's will from Laurie's point of view, being sure to include what he might have been thinking.

∞ Article Link: Autobiographical Roots of Little Women



Term 2

Ch.19-20 "Amy's Will" & "Confidential"

- In what ways did Alcott use the literary device of foreshadowing leading up to Beth's illness? Foreshadowing is when an author gives us hints or clues about what might happen later in the story.
- In what ways does Little Women show that life can be good even through trials and tragedies?

WEEK 6 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 18

Materials: Little Women

→ RECAP

Describe what you've learned about Amy.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.21 "Laurie Makes Mischief, and Jo Makes Peace"

- Were you satisfied with the resolution of the prank in this chapter? Why or why not? If not, how might you have resolved it differently?

★ TEACHER NOTE

Volume 1 of Little Women has two more chapters: "Pleasant Meadows" and "Aunt March Settles the Question." Please have your student read these on their own time. In the next lesson, your student will begin reading Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates.

• EXTRA HELPING

In Ch.21 Jo says, "'Hold your tongue! . . . I came here to moralize, not to hear about things that make me skip to think of.'" Explain why you think she said this.

WEEK 7 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 19

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ INTRO

Following the Civil War, the American public was in dire need of a pleasant distraction. Hans Brinker offered this escape and became an instant bestseller, second only to Charles Dickens in sales. Mary Mapes Dodge made a lasting change in children's literature both as the author of Hans Brinker and editor of St. Nicholas magazine. She brought some of the finest writers of her day to young readers and helped make writing for children lively, thoughtful, and full of imagination.

This story is set in Holland. The Netherlands is the official name of the entire country, while Holland makes up two provinces within the country - North and South Holland. Optional: View Holland on this map. (Scroll down to see the map.)

∞ Map Link: The Netherlands

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.1-2

OR

Ch.1-3

- What have you already learned about Holland?

★ TEACHER NOTE

Choose which pacing option to follow based on the ability and interest of your student(s). See Planning & Prep notes for more details on each option.

• TERMINOLOGY

∞ **Article Link:** Hans Brinker Pronunciation & Corrections (shared with permission)

• EXTRA HELPING

Click "See More" near the top of this page to read a short bio of the author.

∞ **Article Link:** Mary Mapes Dodge Bio

WEEK 8 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 20

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ MAP WORK

Use your atlas or view this map and find Amsterdam, the capital city of the Netherlands. You may want to print the map and tuck it in the book to refer to as you read.

∞ Map Link: Netherlands Map

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ **Video Link:** Dutch Windmill Inside

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

Ch.3-4
OR
Ch.4-6

- How would you describe Hans and Gretel to a friend?

WEEK 9 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 21

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

How did Hans and Gretel find a friend?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.5-7
OR
Ch.7-9

- What “shadows” hang over the Brinker home?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Traditional Dutch Winter Skating

WEEK 10 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 22

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What do you remember about Hans and Gretel's parents?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.8-9
OR
Ch.10-11

- What does the boys' plan to skate nearly fifty miles reveal about them and the time they live in?

→ VIEW

St. Nicholas illustration from St. Nicholas magazine, where Mary Mapes Dodge served as editor.

∞ Image Link: St. Nicholas Illustration

• LITERATURE CONNECTION

Louisa May Alcott (of Little Women fame) wrote for the St. Nicholas magazine!

WEEK 11 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 23

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What do you think will happen next?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.10-11
OR
Ch.12-15

- How do Dutch customs of the Saint Nicholas celebration compare to your own Christmas celebrations?

• EXTRA HELPING

Virtually browse some of the art mentioned in this chapter if time allows.

∞ Link: Rijksmuseum Art

WEEK 12 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 24

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 2

Questions will come from:
Little Women

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 3

WEEK 1 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 25

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What do you remember about the Saint Nicholas celebrations?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.12-13

OR

Ch.16-18

→ MAP WORK

Use your atlas or view this map and find Haarlem.

∞ Map Link: Netherlands Map

- How would you have responded to the "catastrophe" if you had been with the boys?

WEEK 2 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 26

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What happened in the catastrophe? What do you think will happen next?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.14-15

OR

Ch.19-21

- What different kinds of homes are described?
- Why does Gretel struggle with her feelings about her father?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Historic Dutch Home Tour

WEEK 3 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 27

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What do you remember about the Brinker home?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.16-17

OR

Ch.22-23

- Why do you think the author includes so many details about the places the boys visit?

WEEK 4 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 28

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What was the meaning of the "man with four heads"?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.18-19

OR

Ch.24-26

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: Can a Finger Really be Used to Stop a Leaky Dike?

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 3

- What dangers or freedoms come with spending so much time on the ice?

WEEK 5 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 29

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What happened last on the canal?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.20-21

OR

Ch.27-28

- How do group plans reveal who is flexible, selfish, cautious, or brave?

★ TEACHER NOTE

The next lesson includes an optional video for traditional Dutch gingerbread (a five-ingredient quick bread). Look ahead and gather ingredients if you would like to make your own.

WEEK 6 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 30

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What do you remember about the Red Lion so far?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.22-23

OR

Ch.29-32

- How does the author mix comedy and danger? Why do you think she chose to do that?

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

With the remaining time or in the afternoon, learn how to make traditional Dutch gingerbread.

∞ Video Link: Traditional Dutch Gingerbread

WEEK 7 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 31

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

How did the Red Lion become dangerous? What was the resolution?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.24-25

OR

Ch.33-36

→ MAP WORK

Use your atlas or view this map and find Leiden (Leyden is an older spelling).

∞ Map Link: Netherlands Map

- How can visiting museums help us better understand the people, history, and culture of a place?

• EXTRA HELPING

The "Egyptian Museum" is likely the Rijksmuseum van Oudheden.

∞ Link: Rijksmuseum van Oudheden

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 3

WEEK 8 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 32

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What did the boys see in Leyden?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.26-27

OR

Ch.37-40

- How does the quote “it is no sin to love beautiful things if you adapt your material to circumstances” help us think about enjoying beauty wisely?

WEEK 9 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 33

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What stories were shared in the last lesson?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.28-29

OR

Ch.41-42

→ MAP WORK

Use your atlas or view this map and find The Hague.

∞ Map Link: Netherlands Map

- Why is a day of rest important in the story?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Video Link: The Hague Market Today

WEEK 10 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 34

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What happened during the visit to The Hague?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.30-31

OR

Ch.43-44

- As they head home, what has changed because of their journey?

WEEK 11 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 35

Materials: Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ RECAP

What happened as the boys headed home?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.32-33

OR

Ch.45-48

- Why is it sometimes difficult to hope when a situation feels uncertain?
- How can friendship help someone going through tough times?

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

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Term 3

WEEK 12 20m General Lit.: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 36

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:
Hans Brinker or The Silver Skates

→ READ & DISCUSS

Ch.34-35
OR
Finish the book over exam week as needed.

• EXTRA HELPING
∞ **Article Link:** Elfstedentocht:
The Famed Frozen Race

General Lit.: Grades 5-6

Examination

- Term 1** · Little Women: Pilgrim's Progress is referred to multiple times in the book. Explain Jo's Apollyon in Ch.8, Meg's Vanity Fair in Ch.9, or discuss other parallels to Pilgrim's Progress that you've seen.
- Term 2** · Act out one of your favorite scenes from Little Women.
- Term 3** · Hans Brinker: Explain two ways that Hans and Gretel show responsibility and care for their family. What do their actions tell us about the kind of people they are? OR Describe two places the boys visit during their trip and explain what they see or experience at each one.